

we are at it. The generation before mine in my family – my parents, my aunts and uncles – are or were all public servants in some way, shape or form. Teachers, nurses, social workers; all contributing something to society, those noble roles that newspapers and politicians are keen to slap a ‘hero’ sticker on without ever supporting fair pay or working conditions.

This interplay between our money and our work is present for everybody, but I’ve found it to be particularly fraught for freelance and self-employed people. Anna Codrea-Rado, journalist, activist and author of freelancer guide *You’re the Business*, agrees.¹

‘When you’re employed by someone else, you’re paid for your input. You put in the work, and you take your salary home at the end of each month, regardless. But when you work for yourself, you get paid for your output – and if something affects your ability to deliver the work, your finances are directly affected,’ she says. This is something that I had to grapple with fairly early on in my own journey with money. Not long after I started writing about my debt, and my relationship with money, I had to leave my job at a start-up to save my rapidly declining mental health, launching a freelance career with absolutely no safety net and a five-figure sum of debt to service. It was a huge risk, and not something that I could, in good conscience, recommend to anyone else. It paid off eventually, though in the short-term it did complicate things somewhat. I noticed the changes in my relationship with money almost immediately, in ways both good